FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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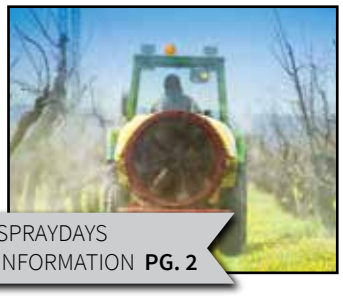
INSIDE



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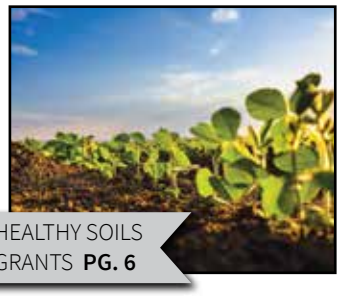

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Kern subbasin given another four months to fix issues with groundwater plans

By Lois Henry, SJV Water

The state Water Resources Control Board voted to give Kern County water managers more time to continue refining plans for how they will bring the critically overdrafted subbasin into balance by 2040.

They now have until June 20 to make revisions to plans that were most recently submitted to the state in December 2024. Those were the fourth versions of groundwater plans Kern has sent to the state since 2020.

The region's probation hearing was continued to Sept. 17, if needed, after Water Board staff reviews the newly refined plans submitted in June.

Board members added a requirement to the reprieve, however. Groundwater agencies must demonstrate that they are reaching out to, and working with, community members and small farmers.

Members of the Semitropic Water Storage District panel, including chair Dan Waterhouse, consultants Richard Howitt and Susan Paulsen, and General Manager Jason Gianquinto, testify before the Water Resources Control Board during the Kern subbasin's probation hearing Feb. 20, 2025. Lois Henry/SJV Water

That language was added after several rural community members objected to giving water managers more time, saying water quality must be fixed now.

"We're tired of seeing our loved ones suffering from illnesses," said a resident of rural Kern County through Jesus Alonso with Clean Water Action who interpreted for him via a remote connection.

After acknowledging the likely outcome of the hearing, that the subbasin would be given more time, Clean Water Action director Jennifer Clary asked board

"Kern Subbasin" continued on page 5

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Your advocate through rising regulatory costs

By Jesse Collier

A recent Cal Poly, San Luis Obispo report, commissioned by the Monterey County Farm Bureau, studied a Salinas Valley lettuce grower and found that their regulatory costs increased by an astounding 1,366% since 2006. While this study is specific to one farm in Salinas Valley, it reflects a larger trend affecting growers across California, including Kings County. The study highlights three major areas in which regulatory costs have surged in Salinas Valley.

1) California and federal labor requirement amendments, such as minimum wage, overtime, and workers' compensation have made labor costs one of the biggest regulatory expenses for farmers. In fact, workers' compensation expenses have increased by 627% since 2006.

2) Water regulation compliance, such as Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA), requires additional monitoring fees, and reporting. In this study, water regulation costs increased by 60% since 2017.

3) Food safety requirements, such as the Leafy Green Marketing Agreement, which forced growers to hire food safety staff, upgrade equipment, and conduct frequent audits, increasing compliance costs by 35% since 2017.

While these regulatory changes are not necessarily "bad" — fair pay, conservation, and safety are important, but unless households want to pay $45 for a head of lettuce, this isn't a sustainable model. While this study focuses on a lettuce grower in Salinas Valley, Kings County farmers face similar labor, water, and food safety regulations, especially in dairy, nut, and seed production. Additionally, our community finds itself in the same boat as farmers in the Salinas Valley with water regulation compliance, particularly the SGMA. The hard working KCFB team is actively advocating for practical groundwater policies that balance sustainability with the realities of farming. We believe that compliance should not come at the cost of family farms, food security, and local economies. We are also suing the California Water Resources Control Board to protect local farmers from skyrocketing compliance costs. These burdensome regulations threaten the viability of family farmers and jeopardize the future of Kings County, and we're committed to ensuring farmers and their families

"Advocate" continued on page 7

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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Executive Director
Dusty Ference
dusty.ference@kcfb.org

Farm Life Advertising
Breanna Larman
blarman@kcfb.org
(559) 584-3557

Farm Life Designer
Beth Greene

CFBF District Representative
Kevin Robertson

Contact
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford, CA 93230
Phone: (559) 584-3557
www.kcfb.org

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SprayDays Information for Growers and Pesticide Applicators

The new regulations, approved by the Office of Administrative Law on December 13, 2024 and effective February 24, 2025, enables the implementation of SprayDays California, a statewide restricted material pesticide application notification system developed by the California Department of Pesticide Regulation (DPR). This system has been designed with input gathered from extensive public outreach and engagement efforts over a four-year period.

DPR anticipates implementing the statewide system in late March 2025.

The new SprayDays system will provide the public with timely information in advance of restricted material pesticide applications in agriculture.

The system will feature a web-based map and option to sign-up for email or text message notifications sent 48 hours prior to the intended use of soil fumigants and 24 hours prior to the intended use of other restricted material pesticides.

The SprayDays website will include:

- Pesticide safety information, including reminders to avoid application sites and follow any posted warning signs.
- Notices that applications may begin within a four-day window or may not occur at all.
- Information on the restricted material pesticides included in the system.
- Context on how pesticides are regulated in California.

What do the regulations require for growers and applicators?

Starting February 24, 2025, the regulations require the electronic submission of all agricultural use Notices of Intent (NOIs) to the County Agricultural Commissioner (CAC) through CalAgPermits, or third-party tools currently used to submit NOIs to CalAgPermits.

If a grower or applicator cannot submit an NOI electronically due to undue hardship (e.g., internet outage, limited access to electricity, or a declared emergency), the CAC may authorize alternative submission formats, including allowing paper submission of NOIs. In such cases, the CAC will upload select NOI data into CalAgPermits.org on behalf of the grower or applicator.

Will this change how growers and applicators currently submit NOIs to their CAC?

The only change is that NOIs must be submitted electronically to the CAC through CalAgPermits except in cases of undue hardship. Growers who already use CalAgPermits to submit NOIs, or third-party tools currently used to submit NOIs to CalAgPermits, will experience no change to their process.

What information will be shared with the public from the NOI through SprayDays California?

The SprayDays California website will share:

- The intended date and time of the pesticide application. (Notifications and the website will clearly state that applications may begin within a four-day window or may not occur at all.)
- The location of the application within a 1x1 mile grid, consistent with information listed on NOIs and reported through Pesticide Use Reports.
- Application information including pesticide product name(s), active ingredient(s), application method, number of treated acres, and U.S. EPA registration number.

This information will be publicly accessible concurrent with NOI submission and will remain on the website for four days following the intended application date.

What information will be shared with the public to support public safety near pesticide applications?

The SprayDays system provides information on the safe and legal use of pesticides in California and reminders to stay away from fields and follow posted warning signs when pesticides are in use.

What additional information will be provided on the SprayDays website?

The SprayDays website will also provide responses to frequently asked questions about the notification system and restricted material pesticides, including context on pesticide regulation in California, explanations of how pesticides are evaluated before registration, and pesticide safety tips, such as reminders to avoid application sites and adhere to posted warning signs.

If a grower or applicator submits an NOI but the application does not occur, is the information removed from SprayDays California?

SprayDays shares NOI information concurrent with its submission to the CAC.

If a grower or applicator decides not to proceed with the application, the information will not be removed. However, the SprayDays website and notifications note prominently that the application may not occur or may be rescheduled for a variety of reasons, including a decrease in the pest presence or changes in weather conditions.

Will the system be updated or changed in the future in response to feedback received after SprayDays launches?

The regulation requires DPR to collect broad public comment, along with comment from the State Board of Food and Agriculture and DPR's Environmental Justice Advisory Committee, on an annual basis to inform a final report on the effectiveness and impact of the regulation issued three years after the system is launched. DPR encourages growers, applicators, all interested parties and the public to provide comments to be included in the annual status update and inform any future adaptations necessary to meet the goal of increased transparency and continued safe, legal pesticide use in California. The comment period will be open in late 2025 or early 2026 and more information will be available on DPR's website (www.cdpr.ca.gov).

How does SprayDays California work in conjunction with the annual pesticide use notification

"Spray Days" continued on page 17

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

State to revisit ban on driverless tractors

During the past half-century, the emergence of new agricultural technology such as aerial drones, autonomous tractors and other equipment has changed the way crops around the world are planted, cared for and harvested. But in California, a regulation from the state's Division of Occupational Safety and Health, or Cal/OSHA, dating to 1977, has prohibited the use of autonomous agricultural equipment without a driver at the helm. After years of advocacy from farm groups, the agency's standards board has empaneled an advisory committee to examine the regulation, signaling it may consider revising it.

Provided by California Farm Bureau Food and Farm News Volume 29, No. 32

Climate Resiliency Strategy for California Agriculture

The California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA) is developing a Climate Resilience Strategy for California Agriculture. The strategy will consolidate the state's various agricultural climate actions into a single framework, providing both the status of current efforts and a roadmap for future initiatives.

The strategy is currently in the drafting phase with public input ongoing and is anticipated to be released for public comment in Summer 2025.

The California Farm Bureau has submitted preliminary written comments, highlighting, among other things, its support for state-funded climate-smart agricultural programs and the need for continued investment in these initiatives. Farm Bureau staff will remain engaged in the development of this strategy and will provide additional input and recommendations to CDFA.

Fire Hazard Severity Zone Recommendations Begin for Local Responsibility Areas

The Office of the State Fire Marshal (OSFM) will begin issuing recommendations for the classification of Fire Hazard Severity Zones (FHSZs) in Local Responsibility Areas (LRAs).

Background

Government Code (GC) 51178 mandates that the State Fire Marshal identify moderate, high, and very high FHSZs based on consistent statewide criteria and the expected severity of fire hazards. GC 51179 requires the State Fire Marshal to make recommendations to local agencies for their designation and adoption by ordinance. Due to resource limitations within OSFM and the impact of recent wildfires in Los Angeles, the agency will distribute these recommendations in four phases over the next six weeks to local jurisdictions in the following areas:

1. Northern California jurisdictions (inland)
2. Northern California jurisdictions (coastal)
3. Central Valley jurisdictions
4. Southern California jurisdictions

OSFM will notify local jurisdictions in Northern California (inland) that may contain moderate, high, very high, or a combination of Fire Hazard Severity Zones within their boundaries. These jurisdictions will receive maps and corresponding data from OSFM's recommendations on Monday, February 10.

Per GC 51179, local agencies have 120 days to designate FHSZs by ordinance. A local agency may, at its discretion, increase the level of FHSZ identified by OSFM or include additional areas within its jurisdiction in its FHSZ ordinance. However, a local agency may not decrease the level of FHSZ identified by OSFM.

Upon adopting an ordinance designating FHSZs, a local agency must provide a copy of the ordinance to the Board of Forestry and Fire Protection within 30 days, per GC 51179(c).

Implications

It is unclear whether these designations will impact California's already fragile insurance market. However, parcels in newly designated risk areas may face non-renewals if they are not already affected. In most instances, insurers are already aware of these risks. The new designations will also expedite enforcement of the "Zone 0" strategy, which requires homeowners in high fire severity areas to maintain an ember-resistant zone within five feet of their homes to reduce wildfire spread. This effort aligns with the Governor's recent Executive Order, which accelerates the implementation of Zone 0 regulations for structures in high-risk fire zones and the State Responsibility Area. Additionally, the Governor has directed OSFM to release updated Fire Hazard Severity Zone maps, adding 1.4 million new acres of land to the highest fire severity tiers. This update will affect building codes and local planning requirements statewide.

Fix Our Forests Act Passes in the House

The U.S. House of Representatives passed the CAFB-supported legislation, the Fix Our Forests Act (H.R. 471). The bill, which passed in a bipartisan 279-141 vote, aims to:

- Streamline and expedite the environmental review process for forest management projects
- Promote improved wildfire mitigation practices
- Limit frivolous lawsuits designed to delay critical forest projects
- Implement additional policies and programs to support rural communities

The legislation now heads to the Senate for consideration.

Provided by CFBF From Sacramento to D.C. Advocacy in Action

CFBF Comments on State Water Board's Draft Order Revising Central Valley Dairy Order

On October 1, 2024, the State Water Resources Control Board released a draft order revising the Central Valley Regional Water Quality Control Board's existing dairy order. The draft order creates a new regulatory framework for nitrogen discharges and makes certain components precedential for dairies statewide. On December 20, 2024, CAFB Legal and Dairy Cares submitted substantial legal and policy comments on the draft order.

Hourly Flex Pricing for Agriculture Option Offered for PG&E Customers

Hourly Flex Pricing is a three-year pilot that offers a risk-free way to lower energy costs and receive funding for automation technology. With Hourly Flex Pricing, electricity prices are the same or lower than comparable rate plans for most of the year. However, during certain times, prices are likely to be higher due to demand on the grid. During the pilot customers will not pay more on Hourly Flex Pricing than they would have on your current rate plan. While on the pilot, customers will receive their regular monthly PG&E energy statement and a supplemental Hourly Flex Pricing statement that tracks performance. After 12 months, if a customer performed better in total on Hourly Flex Pricing than on the current rate plan, a credit would be applied for the difference. Incentives also include receiving a one-time

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"Kern Subbasin" continued from page 1

members to require groundwater agencies to reach out to residents, small water systems and others.

"Delay helps ag, well, great," Clary said. "But it hurts communities. And the attitude seems to be that's OK because they've been getting screwed all along."

Derek Yurosek, chair of the Kern Subbasin Coordination Committee, said he was disappointed to hear that residents were left out and committed to working with other groups to increase outreach.

Though Water Board members, staff and others agreed the Kern subbasin has come a long way from its disjointed start that one water manager likened to "herding cats," the plans are still missing the mark in several key areas.

The plans are still not protective enough of drinking water wells, allowing up to 255 wells to go dry by 2040, Water Board staff noted. The problem remains "minimum thresholds," a sort of rock bottom line for groundwater levels that water managers must strive to avoid.

Earlier Kern subbasin plans had much lower minimum thresholds and groundwater agencies right next door to one another often had wildly different thresholds.

Though the newest plans raised the thresholds an average 33 feet, in some cases more than 100 feet, across the subbasin and capped all thresholds at no more than 61 feet below historic lows, it wasn't protective enough given the disparity in hydrogeological conditions in the subbasin, according to staff.

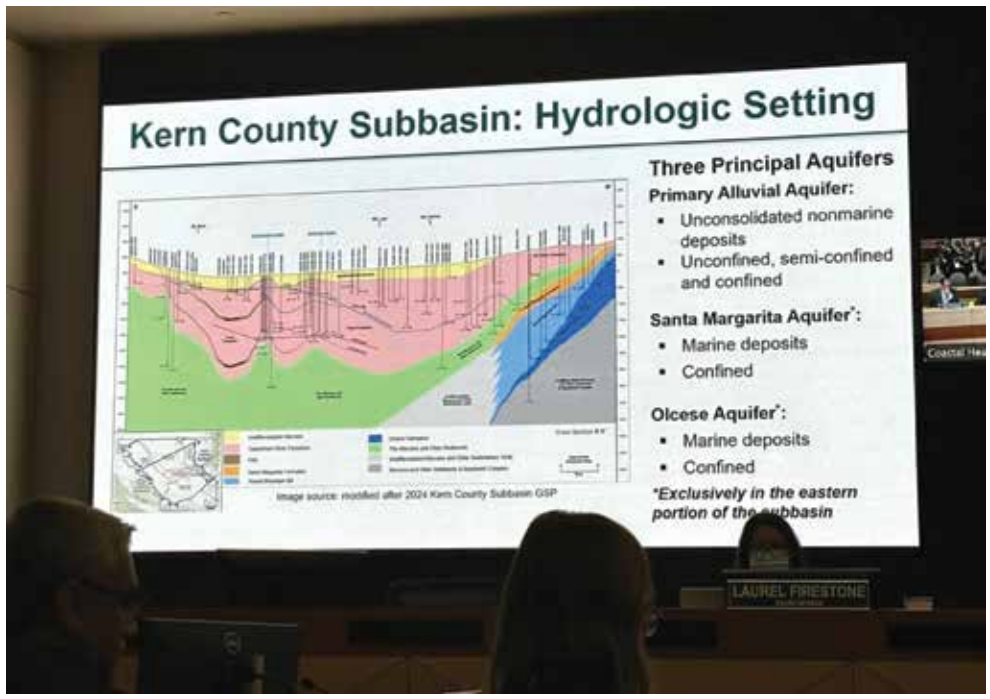
A team of consultants representing the Kern subbasin detailed how exceedances of those minimum thresholds would trigger a number of actions and if wells go dry, Self-Help Enterprises would provide a rapid response.

That program is already funded with a revolving $3.5 million reserve, meaning more money will be put in as funds are spent, the Kern team explained. Halting or slowing subsidence, or land sinking, was also still an issue.

In what could become a showdown with Kern County's other main economic driver – oil production – Water Board staff wanted the new groundwater plans to quantify the causes behind subsidence, meaning who's to blame.

That has become a ticklish issue on Kern's western fringes where ag and oil are mixed and subsidence has crimped the California Aqueduct's carrying capacity by more than 40%.

Water Board staff acknowledged that recent actions by the Westside Water District Authority to ban groundwater pumping for a 2.5 mile-zone around the aqueduct, were a good first step.



A slide presented by state Water Resources Control Board staff shows various hydrogeologic areas in the Kern subbasin. Lois Henry/SJV Water

Kern's consultants noted that while there has been greater subsidence in western Kern County and along the Tulare County border, the majority of subsidence in the subbasin has been less than one foot since 2015.

Kern has also committed $40 million to add capacity to the southern portion of the Friant-Kern Canal, which had to be rebuilt along a 33-mile stretch north of Kern because it had sunk so much that its carrying capacity was cut by 60%.

"Kern has been very cooperative and transparent, which has been a welcome change compared to the Tule subbasin," said Katie Duncan, senior water resources engineer for Friant Water Authority.

She referred to the subbasin just north of Kern County, which was put on probation last Septemberby the Water Board.

The Tulare Lake subbasin, which covers most of Kings County, was put on probation in April 2024. But sanctions, including mandatory well meters, registration and fees, are on hold in Kings County pending the outcome of a lawsuit.

"AG NEWS" continued from page 4

reimbursement for automation technology purchased to manage your energy use during the pilot. The reimbursement level is $160/kW (approximately $120/HP) of enrolled customer controllable load, capped at 100% of your costs. The pilot ends December 31, 2027. At that time, customers will remain on their current rate plan. While customers are encouraged to stay on for the duration of the risk-free pilot, they can end participation at any time. The risk-free nature of the program and the upgrade incentives for those that may already be contemplating greater automation may be a great benefit. More information is available at pge.com/hfp or through an account representative.

Comments on Proposed Water Board "Phase 2" Sacramento River Watershed Bay-Delta Water Quality Control Plan Amendments

CFBF submitted comments on the State Water Resources Control Board's draft "Phase 2" Sacramento-San Joaquin River Bay-Delta water quality control plan amendments. The Board's "Phase 2" amendments consider two basic alternatives for required instream flows to protect native fish in the Sacramento River Watershed and Delta. One is a "regulatory pathway" and potential "regulatory backstop," based on a proposed 45 to 65-percent, January through June "unimpaired flow" requirement. The other is a comprehensive water user-backed mix of flow and non-flow commitments, within a certain "adaptive implementation" framework, referred to as the "Healthy Rivers and Landscape" proposal. CAFB's comments focused on potential severe water supply and economic impacts and on various technical and practical difficulties associated with the Board's "regulatory pathway" proposal. The comments also focused on various comparative advantages of the proposed "Healthy Rivers and Landscapes" proposal. How to deal with parties not part of the current "Healthy Rivers and Landscapes" "voluntary agreement" proposed and water quality and other unique concerns in the Sacramento-San Joaquin River Delta were additional areas of focus. Based on public input and ongoing work and discussions, the Board is expected to consider a revised set of amendments for potential adoption sometime in 2025.

Content provided by CFBF In Brief

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EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

Healthy Soils Grant Program

Excelsior Kings River RCD will cost share projects aimed at improving on-farm soil health and on-farm composting

OBJECTIVE

Cost share healthy soils projects including but not limited to:
compost applications, mulching, cover-cropping and whole orchard recycling

SERVICE AREA

Portions of Kings, Tulare, and Fresno Counties

**Members of the Socially Disadvantaged Farmers and Ranchers (SDFR) Community are encouraged to apply and may qualify for additional funding.*

APPLICATION TIMELINE

May 1 – June 30, 2025

APPLY IN-PERSON:

Kings County Farm Bureau Office
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford

FOR MORE INFORMATION:

www.ekrcd.org
(559) 309-4030
info@ekrcd.org

TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE AVAILABLE BY APPOINTMENT

"Advocate" continued from page 1

thrive while doing what they do best.

Farmers across California have been forced to take on additional costs — even debt — and our hard-working, rugged friends in Kings County are no exceptions. In 2023, the gross value of all crops and products in Kings County decreased by 16.9% (Kings County Department of Agriculture, 2024). If these trends persist, local agriculture is threatened; a concerning reality, given the fact that Kings County ranks 1st in California for cotton lint, cottonseed, and wheat production, 3rd for corn, nectarines, plums, and tomatoes and 4th for milk, pistachios, and peaches (County of Kings, 2022).

"It's one thing to say that costs are rising — which we all knew — but when you see a nearly 15-fold increase, you realize how bad things have gotten," said Dusty Ference, Executive Director of the Kings County Farm Bureau. "This study is exactly what we need right now, as there is hard, empirical data to show those in power that California agriculture is seriously threatened." Hopefully, more studies are carried out on the subject so the agricultural advocates like KCFB have more concrete proof to keep agriculture sustainable, rather than just anecdotal evidence.

While the 1,366% increase in regulatory costs is staggering, it's important to recognize that some of this rise is due to inflation. The study does not indicate whether its calculations were adjusted for inflation, but for context, what cost $100 in 2006 now costs about $160 today (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025)— but we all know fuel, wages, and water fees have gone up much more than that. Even after accounting for inflation, it's clear that regulatory costs have far outpaced farm revenue, reinforcing the study's credibility and highlighting the urgent need for reform.

Of course, the agricultural community isn't against regulation; we want to nurture our planet and keep everyone nourished and healthy like we always have. Problems arise when social and economic pressures from disasters such as bacterial outbreaks, droughts, livestock disease pressure policymakers to react quickly and pass a bill to provide relief and change to the community. When policymakers create solutions without consulting with the growers — agriculture's front line workers — they fail to understand their systems, farmgate pricing, burdens, or even ideas. Additional regulation may decrease use of pesticides or lower the risk of E. Coli outbreaks, but when farms can't keep up with the added costs and close up shop, the ripple effect is palpable nationwide. Thousands of employees lose their jobs, leading to financial hardship and additional strain on local, state, and federal welfare resources. If the farm was a major producer of a product, that may lead to a shortage, and a competitor could drive their prices up, leading to some families not purchasing vegetables because they cannot afford them.

The solution isn't zero regulations, but it is simple: keep open lines of communication and regular meetings between farmers, advocacy groups, and policymakers, as we understand the lives of farmers across Kings County. Since 1918, the Kings County Farm Bureau has been advocating on behalf of the farmers, ranchers, and dairymen to fight for better policies and legislation at the local, state, and federal levels.

"We understand it's been a difficult time for the agricultural community, but Kings County farmers have a long history of resilience," Dusty Ference continues. "Your ancestors, land, and community have persevered through countless droughts, floods, pests, diseases, economic downturns, changes in technology and farming practices, and we're still one of the leading agricultural counties in California! We're going to get through this and come out stronger."

The good news is that we aren't alone in these efforts. In addition to research from the Monterey County Farm Bureau and Cal Poly, other farmer-led coalitions, such as Sustainable Conservation and Farmer- and Rancher-Led Climate Change Solutions, represent the agricultural community while working with policymakers to write bills that benefit both parties. These alliances, along with the dedicated work of the KCFB, are crucial in the fight for sustainable agriculture, but our strength lies in our members. We encourage all local agricultural professionals to become members to help us build a stronger, more resilient community. Already a member? Please help us spread the word! The more members we have, the stronger our voice will be from Sacramento to Washington, DC. Let's work together to protect the future of Kings County agriculture. Join or share today: https://www.kcfb.org/membership.

"Spray Days" continued from page 2

requirements near schools and childcare facilities?

The new regulations do not exempt growers or applicators from providing annual notification to school sites within ¼ mile of their production agricultural properties, as required by 3CCR 6692. For more information on pesticide use near school sites:
www.cdpr.ca.gov/docs/enforce/pesticide_applications_near_schoolsites.htm

Who should I contact if I have questions about the system or how it works?

- For information on submitting your NOI electronically or regarding hardship exceptions, please contact your County Agricultural Commissioner.
- For questions about the SprayDays California website, contact the Department of Pesticide Regulation at spraydays@cdpr.ca.gov

SGMA Defense Fund Expenses

May: $31,873	October: $32,920
June: $28,057	November: $19,349
July: $44,231	December: $59,887
August: $70,863	January: $43,695
September: $49,217	February: $5,325

To date investment in attorneys fees funded by the SGMA Defense Fund:

$385,392

INVEST TODAY
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SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

KCFB's legal challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board has already saved growers in the Tulare Lake Subbasin millions of dollars and kept state intervention off your farm. But the fight isn't over yet—and we need your support to finish strong. By contributing, you'll play a crucial role in securing a win for California agriculture, protecting farms, and ensuring the future of farming in California. This is a pivotal moment—your support can make all the difference. **Join us in defending California's agricultural community!**

Contact KCFB by phone at 559-584-3557, via email at kcfb@kcfb.org, or visit the KCFB website for more information.

HOW YOU CAN HELP:

$8 PER ACRE: GROWERS IN THE TULARE SUB-BASIN
$4 PER ACRE: GSA ORGANIZATIONS
$4 PER ACRE: GROWERS OUTSIDE THE TULARE SUB-BASIN

BUSINESS SUPPORT LEVELS: $2,500 • $5,000 • $10,000

Please make checks payable to:

Kings County Farm Bureau
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Hanford, CA 93230

Include SGMA Defense Fund on the memo line

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

MEMBERSHIP APPRECIATION NIGHT

VISALIA Rawhide™

FREE TICKETS!

Thursday, May 8 6:30 pm
Rawhide Stadium, Visalia

As a **THANK YOU** to our valued members, sponsors and SGMA Defense Fund donors, you're invited to join us at the Visalia Rawhide game

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Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

California's Weighmaster Enforcement Program

In industries ranging from Agriculture to construction, the accurate measurement of weight is critical for ensuring fair trade, proper compliance with laws, and maintaining safety standards. This is where the role of the weighmaster becomes essential. A weighmaster is a person who is authorized to weigh goods and certify the weight of materials, goods, or commodities in transactions or operations. In California, the importance of weighmasters is emphasized through the California Department of Food and Agriculture's (CDFA) comprehensive weighmaster enforcement program. The County Sealer of Weights and Measures plays a crucial role in the CDFA's Division of Measurement Standards (DMS) enforcement program, ensuring that the public and businesses alike are protected from inaccurate weights and measurements.

Weighmasters are crucial in a wide range of industries. They work in places like scale houses, recycling centers, construction sites, and agricultural fields, where weight-based transactions or assessments are common. A weighmaster is typically an individual who is employed by a company or business that is authorized to perform official weight measurements. The responsibilities of a weighmaster include weighing bulk commodities or products, ranging from agricultural goods like grain and produce to construction materials and recycled materials. They ensure that the weight is accurate and matches the agreed upon quantity for transactions. Weighmasters are required to keep accurate records of all weight tickets issued, including details such as the weight, type of goods, date, and the identity of the parties involved. These records are subject to inspection to ensure they meet legal requirements. This is particularly important in transactions involving bulk goods, where weight discrepancies can lead to significant financial losses or legal issues. After weighing the goods, the weighmaster provides a certified weight ticket that records the weight of the materials or goods. This certificate is used in transactions to establish the exact amount of products being traded, bought, or sold. By ensuring that the measurements are accurate, weighmasters prevent fraud, misrepresentation, and unfair pricing practices. A specific duty of the County Sealer is to maintain records of inspections, test and enforcement actions on weighmasters and to report the findings to the DMS.

The state's weighmaster enforcement program is designed to ensure that weight measurement practices remain fair, transparent, and in compliance with state laws. The program serves several important functions such as weighmaster licensing and certification. Weighmasters in California must be licensed by the state. This ensures that the individuals performing official weight measurements are trained and qualified to do so. To become a licensed weighmaster, candidates must meet specific education and experience requirements. Additionally, they must pass exams that test their knowledge of the legal and technical aspects of weighing. The program regularly monitors weighmasters to ensure they are operating in compliance with the law. County inspectors conduct inspections that check the validity of the weighmaster's certifications, as well as testing scales and other measurement tools ensuring they are properly calibrated and functioning. This helps avoid discrepancies that could lead to unfair trading or violations of state regulations. If inaccuracies are found, the Sealer may require the device to be repaired, replaced or recalibrated.

The weighmaster enforcement program plays a vital role in protecting consumers and businesses from deceptive practices. By certifying weight measurements, the program helps to ensure that customers receive what they've paid for, and that businesses operate on a level playing field. Whether in agricultural commodities, construction materials, or waste management, accurate weights are a key part of transparent business practices. The program also ensures that weighing equipment, such as truck scales, platform scales, and other devices used in weight measurement, meet California's standards. County Sealer inspectors check these scales, ensuring they are calibrated regularly and inspected to avoid faulty readings that could lead to unfair pricing or loss of product. County inspectors often engage in educating local businesses to ensure they understand their obligation regarding weights and measures, helping prevent violations before they occur.

If a consumer or business suspects that a weighmaster has issued incorrect weight tickets or that a scale is improperly calibrated, they can file a complaint with the County Sealer of DMS. County staff handles complaints from consumers regarding incorrect measurements. The county, through the enforcement program, investigates these complaints and can take corrective actions, including fines, penalties, or suspension of the weighmaster's license. In industries where weight-based pricing is common, such as agriculture or recycling, weighmasters ensure that both parties in a transaction are receiving a fair deal. The California weighmaster program helps maintain trust in these transactions by confirming that goods are weighed accurately, and that there is no manipulation or misrepresentation of the weights.

Weighmasters play a crucial role in maintaining the integrity of weight measurements, ensuring fair trade, and supporting consumer protection in California's economy. Enforced at the local level by the County Sealer, the state's weighmaster enforcement program is dedicated to upholding high standards for certification, licensing, and compliance. Through rigorous monitoring and regulation, the program helps ensure that California's businesses and consumers can trust the accuracy of weight-based transactions across a variety of industries. This structure fosters a fair marketplace, where individuals and companies can operate with confidence, knowing that they are protected from fraud or inaccuracies in weight measurements. Please contact the Kings County Agricultural Department at 559-852-2830 if you have questions.

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

The Kings County Sheriff's Office Rural Crime Task Force is currently conducting several investigations.

February: Throughout the months of January and February, the Kings County Rural Crimes Task Force has continued to stay busy investigating a variety of thefts to include copper wire theft, beehive theft, heavy equipment theft, and various other agricultural equipment thefts. There has been a sharp rise in copper wire thefts and equipment thefts. These variety of cases are difficult to investigate but the Rural Crimes unit has been busy setting up trail cameras and following up with recycling centers to identify suspects and bring them into custody. We have also been investigating several AT&T wire thefts, which have also been on a steady rise. Due to AT&T wire running along very rural areas in the county, this leads suspects into orchards and equipment yards in said areas causing the rise in thefts along county lines and these rural areas.

The Kings County Rural Crimes unit worked several cases alongside and with the help of several bordering counties including Fresno County and Tulare County Ag units. Together, we were able to identify suspect vehicles in related thefts that cross county lines. A white Toyota Tacoma pickup was identified as a vehicle that's been used in several copper wire thefts from the south part of the county. Our unit has also located and recovered a stolen Gator from Verdegaal Brothers Inc., which was recovered near 9th Ave and Hanford Armona Rd. We've learned suspects will often stage equipment after stealing it, mainly within orchards or rural areas, and return at a later time to recover it. Through recent investigations and with the help of the Flock camera system, we were able to identify and arrest five individuals we believed were involved in the theft of the Gator mentioned earlier and who we believe were also involved in recent AT&T and copper wire thefts.

As always, it is imperative that if anyone knows of or hears of anyone buying or selling obviously stolen equipment, call the Sheriff's Office. We highly encourage anyone to call the Sheriff's Office if they find equipment or any items that seem out of place on their property that don't belong to them. We continue to investigate all ag-related thefts and encourage members to call and report all ag-related crimes. If we do not receive calls from our members and community, we may not be aware of certain crimes occurring in your area. If you have any questions, please call me or any of our unit members anytime.

DA Investigator Ward **(559) 309-6367**
Detective Estrada **(559)212-7512**

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ATTORNEYS AT LAW

502 W. Grangeville Blvd. Hanford, California 93230
Telephone (559) 585-7330 Facsimile (559) 585-7335
www.diaslaw.com

Michael A. Dias • Jonette M. Montgomery
Steven E. Alfieris • Ella R. Floresca
David M. Lange • Dustin J. Moses
Alyssa T. Ransom
Attorneys at Law

Jimmy J. Rodriguez • Alicia D. West
Of Counsel

HANSEN INDUSTRIES, INC.

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